Kejriwal had already challenged Modi's business links—Rahul looked like a copycat. If Rahul had wanted to seriously interrogate Modi's Gujarat model, then he should have done it much earlier. The 2012 Gujarat assembly elections would have perhaps been a good time. A Team Modi member admitted to me, 'We were far more vulnerable then. That was the big missed opportunity for the Congress.' Now, it seemed almost like an afterthought. In the decade after 2002, the Congress's principal attack on Modi had been his handling of the riots. He was for the party, as Sonia Gandhi had described him, a '*maut ka saudagar*'. The gambit hadn't worked. The trenchant criticism only allowed Modi to play victim. Where the Congress failed to challenge the Modi narrative was in his claims to be solely responsible for the Gujarat growth story. 'Modi makes Gujarat seem like a land of milk and honey and he as the only development-oriented leader. We never did enough to puncture holes in his storyline,' a Congress strategist confessed later.

The list of mistakes didn't end just there. At a rally in Indore, Rahul claimed that Pakistan's intelligence agency, ISI, had contacted some Muzaffarnagar Muslim families who had been affected by the riots. It gave Modi just the opening he was looking for. 'Rahul should name the families, else apologize to all Muslim youth,' was Modi's riposte.

The truth is that an Intelligence Bureau (IB) report had pointed to possible ISI links in western UP. But the report, like many IB reports, was short on specifics. 'You don't make IB reports the subject of a political debate in this manner,' a senior IB official told me. If Rahul was drawing attention to a national security concern, then he should have addressed it differently. By going public with a sensitive issue, he had angered local Muslims who felt they were being stereotyped as potential terrorists, and confirmed the worst fears of Hindus who were already feeling they were under siege. It was a unique role reversal. Modi was now talking the language of communal amity, Rahul of polarization.

Out of curiosity, I tried to find out who was Rahul's speech-writer. Typically, I was given no clear answer. 'He has a team to help him,' I was told. So who was in this 'team'? 'Well, Jairam Ramesh used to be involved,